

20260914 Gayan

1. Introductions: We're grad students at Cornell Tech looking for some expert guidance for a problem we've chosen to tackle around how cities might better learn what their residents need.
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3. In terms of the structure for this conversation – it's going to be super informal. We'll probably just switch off asking you questions. Does that sound alright? ... I'll start us off.
4. ★ Could you lead us through (as you understand it) the step by step process for when a resident raises an issue/concern, where it's routed to, and what comes after? Feel free to provide as much or as little detail as you want to provide.
5. Where are the biggest pain points in learning what residents need or engaging with residents? What work do you do that can not be automated? What can be?
 - MTA is not part of the NYC DOT. Partially by governor and partially by the mayor and all the state employee. Work on bus network redesign and
 - Bit of back and forth between
 - Aware of the problems that users have
 - Service reliable
 - Track a lot of those through survey. Track trends as they go up and down.
 - Every so often ha
 - Sometime representatives (**community board?**)
 - Social media accounts bubble up to leadership.
 - Will do analysis to see if it is a real pr
 - Route planning
 - Network redesigns
 - Data
 - Collect Passenger ridership (autoamatic from door sensors, or **paid?** So can see buses)
 - Feeds into operation planning . Use ReMix, which allows them to redraw busroutes to simulate how. Put bustops at passenger centers. Will shift set of trips on routes .
 - Less likely to do large scale changes.
 - Shifts in service (shut down a lot of service to meet the lack of demand). Spikes in demands are actually smaller than demand spikes from day-to-day community. Not drastic in terms of NYC.
 - Where are there pain points? Would make it easier. Constraints. Reality is already a census of information that generates this dataset for them. Have models of how people tend to do that travel. (Ex. 300 people)
 - Transit has live tracking access to subways.

- Missed demand: How many people are coming to a bus stop waiting for a bus, realizing for some reason it didn't come, and then decide not to take the MTA and a different service.
 - MTA app is the same type of system (Transit, CityMapper)
 - Operational data siloes and expanding that to different projects within the MTA, presuming the data already exists there. Becomes an internal project of acquiring.
 - Program for the partnership of New York. Companies will pitch through new data, new tool for operations, that they may/may not take onto pilots. Had success with companies that put sensors on rain and rolling stock and bad machinery.
 - Blind spots
 - Could use station comfort levels (temperature).
 - Piping the heat from the subways to heat municipal buildings but no broad data on this .
 - As someone that works in government, what do you think about social mediafying 311 engagement?
 - People don't care about their complaints. Gamified features is interesting. Concerned
 - Usually only weirdos that
 - It ends up in a dataset somewhere
 - Better sense of tracking a complaint. Will submit a hot car complaint in the subway and will never hear about it -> would rather have a service now app where can take a picture (geotagged), privacy tracked, appropriately anonymized.
 - Gap between you want something and seeing you. Closing the loop. "This is the city list"
 - Why do you think the rest of the city is lagging behind? Institutional inertia. Agencies already have been doing their work and established processes and it does take some support and it take support in the weeds and above to have a modernization effort done there. They already know how to do a lot of things (for 10-15 years).
 - MTA before 2020 did not have a centralized data team. MTA Open Data pass in 2021. Makes sense to have another team responsible for that. Centralizing the data at the MTA itself. Pressure from the state. Hiring the appropriate team (data scientists). Private sector is paying way more.
 - Transit tech lab
6. Did we miss anything?
 7. Blue Sky?
 8. Are there other folks in the city you'd recommend we speak to?
 9. Thank you so much.

20260914 Joe Morrisroe, Julane Lowe (Deputy Commissioner OTI)

About them

- **Joe:** Direct and lead New York City's customer-facing operations, through the 311 Customer Service Center and online website. Enabling access to information and services for over 8.6 million New Yorkers, through a 24/7 multi-lingual, multi-site operation under the Mayor's Office of Technology and Innovation (OTI). Deliver operational and technology solutions and customer satisfaction for the best government customer care platform in the nation.
- **Julane:** Director of Planning at NYC311

1. Introductions: We're grad students at Cornell Tech looking for some expert guidance for a problem we've chosen to tackle around "How might we help cities better learn what their residents need?" We understand that 311NYC has around 94% customer satisfaction rating, which is literally incredible, so amazing job by the both of you and the wider team. But we want to know where we can help. We want to build a piece of public interest technology to help service the needs of the either fellow residents or for city government.
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 5. Where are the biggest pain points in learning what residents need or engaging with residents?
- About 311
 - Tackle academic efforts. Whose underserved.
 - a. 3.5M service requests every year. Not the highest volume reason why. Generates thermal apps and neighborhood. Chicago has 3.5M contacts per year.
 - b. Most of the requests is Information services business. 37M contacts each year. Connect people with human resources, food pantry. Infrastructure, appointments, all can be
 - c. Most people engage on a self serve basis through website and mobile app. Will take automated announcements they play and that satisfies needs.
 - d. Most people will look at geography, but only on service requests.
 - Biggest problem is people don't use 311.
 - e. Outreach is the greatest effort of the campaign this year. Complaint hotline
 - i. **There's SeeClickFix, ReportedNYC**
 - f. Want to have it more customer orientated
 - Data Problem
 - Are there underserved communities and if so, why? And the assumptions
 - Instill some trust into the government. It's unlikely not aware. Non-empiracle data is don't trust government but focusing on privacy. Don't collect data unless specific to the complaint. Goal is to give your answer.

- People calling about neonatal care, private information. Commitment to trust and privacy is holding up.
- **What is being done?**
 - There is not an outreach effort. 311 doesn't have an advertising budget. Periodically worked with selected officials (flyers, table event). Not really a concentrated effort. Plan for next year. 51 council.
 - Resource shortage. Target where they should be based on vulnerable communities.
 - Best work is through own staff. Call center representatives will hear focus groups. Nothing formal focus groups so far.
- Is the city *learning*?
 - They are intake not outreach. Don't want to contact them. Accounts could engage.
- **How many are on mobile?**
- **Advertising**
 - Mayor announce
 - Council members get upset
 - Lack of concerted outreach - not a problem
- Other PublicTech Apps
 - SeeClickFix. Are competitors.
 - Connected with
 - Who is served? Who is underserved?
 - Most 311 don't have an outreach budget.
 - Trials with AI vendors. Voice AI, did a lot of demos. Those vendors would be able to use their APIs to be able to connect.
- Current tech stack
 -
- **Budget**
 - Emergency
- 6. Did we miss anything?
- 7. Blue Sky?
- 8. Are there other folks in the city you'd recommend we speak to?
- 9. Thank you so much.

20260911 Department of Social Services

Pinto

- NYC Human Resources food stamp department. People have all the services they need. The only thing that they might need more of are interpreters. Too few people doing too many things -- nothing that technology will help with.

Mr. Vargas

- NYC Homeless Services Department. Office of Ombudsman. They have all the services they need, they just don't do it. Issues with the systems updating, not compatible -- no

good, so connected us to Luis (IT guy). It's super complicated because people who live in shelters don't have family and want to stay because can talk to people like Mr. Vargas. Another issue is leaders don't start from the ground up, so they don't actually know the real state of things. You also don't hear about any of the good "wins". People come here because they don't have a plan. Sometimes they won't even take help.

Mr. K

- Works at the check in room. Also believes everyone has the services they need. It's not hard to sign up but people don't want to learn the technology. They just want others to do it for them and get angry if you don't.

Security Guard at Career and Training Services

- People come out of the experience satisfied. Once people get there they are happy with the service they receive.

20260911 Advisor Meeting

Focus on derisking barriers to people supplying that information.

Enhancing existing apps

- Rare unless working as a plugin
- Occupying role as a data broker. Could be data engineering. Could work as an API that other organizations can plug into.
- Is there a sense of privacy that people want to plug into
- Will reach out to Greg

20260910 Erik

Non Profit Social work

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- These clients he works with are the underbelly of the broken system.
 - City of LA and then County of LA and then council districts. Parks and Rec. County owned sidewalk, Parks and Rec owned the bottom of the river.
 - LA Homeless Outreach Portal. Get requests assigned to the different outreach teams that are composed of case managers.
 - Nothing proactive about the work they do.

- Except emergency
- Or, someone from the council district. Community members go to their council person or their council person office and they will ask outreach team to go to those spots. Council person.
- g their situation. And people who don't have problems, and get worse at the motels.
- Sometimes it's from businesses, police officers, members of the council district. Sometimes its someone making a complaint, sometimes its people advocating for them. That directs outreach for the day
- So much is about
- Erik is on the public spaces team – focused on parks, libraries,. People that are unhoused and staying at the location are less street culture (Encampments). Encampments are no longer allowed. More solitary.
- Different neighborhoods are set for every day. Westwood day (westwood park, library) then talk about case management with them
- Getting them documents for housing purposes, mental health.
- Making referrals.
- When a match comes through.
- Drive someone to a DMV or a leasing appointment.

BUT he hasn't done any canvassing outreach. It's been nonstop tasks of getting someone into a shelter or getting them medical. People make a plan and their phone dies. Or an urgent match comes through to a traditional site transfer . Constantly having to triage.

Probably have a full caseload of clients without even finding clients. Built relationships with ambassadors of the library. Campus minister at UCLA, and be friends with people that are unhoused. Community involvement, planning grassroots type stuff. Creating connection and relationships with people that are living outside.

5. Where are the biggest pain points in learning what residents need or engaging with residents? What work do you do that can not be automated? What can be?
 - Karen Bass is doing something called "Pathway to Home" or "Encampment Resolution" and this is when there is a major encampment, will do encampment resolution project, and pay for these people to go into motels for transitional housing and case managers are supposed to get them connected to permanent housing.
 - Paid by the government. Some people go to the motels with no major substance use problems but because there is extreme lack of support people end up keeping that habit in the comfort of being inside and not improv
6. Learning from academia
 - Harm reduction - providing clean pipes and needles for people to. School campuses supplies safe sex supplies.
 - Having these types of things aren't enabling them, it's making sure they stay alive so we have a chance to help them
 - If they don't have fentanyl test strips or clean needles "They're going to use anyways"

- Housing first - people need housing first. They're not going to be able to work on anything else if they are unhouse
 - But transitional housing sites have amnesty lockers where people can have all their substances (cannot use onsite) but can use it across.
- 7. Did we miss anything?
- 8. Blue Sky?
- 9. Are there other folks in the city you'd recommend we speak to?
- 10. Thank you so much.

Technology

- HMIS Clarity and Champ are used to collect data on houseless people. Clarity has a new feature that allows you to invite clients to view a version of their own profile.

Blue Sky

- Map where you can see requests, where you can see where service providers are going.
- This encampment is here and you can see that people are really going
- Medical teams, outreach mental health provider. Who's there, whose left. There's a street with lots of RVs.
 - Medical and mental health is needed here.
- Everything in the system right now is referral based. He has to individually refer. Enabling service providers that are motivated.
- People who are boots on the ground work care. But administrative structures are more prone to corruption and laziness but rely on those structures to be told what to do.
- Visualize instead of a top down approach where council person told manager to tell people.
- Instead, let boots on the ground people to have accurate updates of what's going on. Address issues in the system. Taking power away from people at the top because that's where most of the issues lie.
- The system doesn't actually help. It's the people that are doing the work. Coordinating with the mental health clinics, etc.
- Dynamic platform have a community facing side and an institution facing side.
- Technology rooting us in physicality and locality. Feels nebulous

Trust Issues

- People have extreme trust issues due to the current administration, fraud discovered in LAHSA (top dogs of LA homeless authority) and they are a city agency that subcontracts out to smaller services
- LAHSA got defunded because there was 300M dollars fraudulently wasted
- HSH is now owned by the county
- St Josephs (where Erik works) are government subcontracts
- He calls himself a "humanitarian salesman" but try to convince themselves to use the system to their advantage.
- Worries that the administration was going to use that information to

Assumptions

- If city knows what their residents need then they will address them.
- The city is just community members, the people that live in the city

- They can work hand in hand

20260910 Jane

1. (Rachel) Introductions: We're grad students at Cornell Tech looking for some expert guidance for a problem we've chosen to tackle how might we improve how communities shape the laws that govern them?
2. ★ Before we begin, do you mind if we **record** this conversation for note taking purposes? Great! ...would y'all want to start off by introducing yourself, what you do, why you love NYC?
3. What is the step by step process in terms of engaging students for civic engagement?
 - a. At the start of the academic year, clubs are formed
 - b. There is a community service that undergirds this effort
 - i. Driven by PHD students
 - ii. Helps having students who are here for more than a year
 - iii. Helpful to have masters in 2 year programs
 - c. Clubs are very busy, so Jane has set up an engagement process:
 - i. Participate in the Halloween extravaganza on the Island (organized by RIOC)
 - ii. Roosevelt Island Disabled Association: Community Service Club supports that as well with food distro events
 - iii. 2 1-to-1 Tech Days: Event for Older adults on the Island; Club organizes students and Jane coordinates with the communities of older adults on the Island (November and Feb/March)
 - iv. Food Pantry is some Friday (one-off)
 - d. Students get busy and this presents difficulties
 - e. Not a lot of feedback on the 1:1 tech events
 - i. Usually get rave word of mouth reviews
 - ii. Older adults are very grateful
4. How would you define her relationship with local gov and other entities in NYC?
 - a. RIOC governs the Island for the below
 - b. Roosevelt island is on city land leased to the state, extended till 2078.
 - c. Jane has been working this role since 2014, is retiring in December and thinking about handing things over. 2017 is when Cornell Tech was built out.
 - i. Thinking about onboarding/handover
 - d. Very focused on activities/events that her office runs and sharing resources with folks
 - e. She communicates with them
 - i. Has a list of 900 folks on Google
 - ii. Collection of everyone she has come in contact with on the Island
 - iii. Whenever she has something they might be interested in, she blasts out an email to the full (?) list
 - iv. Shares virtual event info to these folks
 - v. Communications happen on multiple fronts

1. Attends Hospital task force meetings
 2. Long-term relationship with Director of Senior Center
 3. Post on behalf of Main Street Theatre
- vi. Communications are a challenge
 1. Allege that students never get past the subway and Jane wants to drive that
 2. Student Volunteer Day, originally scheduled in Spring (now Fall) becomes a major vehicle for folks to learn more about Roosevelt Island and to engage institutions
 3. Also, no staff, only her upkeep, communicating, etc.
- f. Also has relationships with other institutions
 - i. PSI School
 - ii. Senior Center
 - iii. Art Gallery
 1. Started sitting in the Art Gallery between 10-4 when the Gallery just featured the drawings of the campus to come
 2. Would meet folks that way and foster relationships
 - iv. Four Freedoms Park
 - v. Hospital on the Island
 - vi. Built these relationships over time since 2014 – and even before
- g. A lot of these relationships were driven over time
 - i. Before she came here, she worked for a city council person that represented Roosevelt Island
 - ii. Walking round and meeting with folks is going to be key – pounding the pavement, talking with folks IRL, asking about what we can do
- h. A lot of the work at CT is siloed and relationships develop outside of Jane
 - i. Faculty creates connections that she might/might not be aware of
 - ii. Would love a tool to keep all staff more integrated with Jane's office
5. ★ How do you share your needs, whether resourcing or funding, with city government? Are there tools you use to track this info?
 - a. Could really use help with this bit (tools/tracking)
 - i. Def sees the value in a tool for feedback after engagement oppos – for both students and stakeholders students engage with
 - ii. Cannot track how relationships
 - b. Not great at documenting things
 - c. Handover notes are very necessary, thinking through everything that needs to continue.
6. What are the pain points involved in that process – for either communities or governments?
 - a. Finding people to replace long standing roles
7. What is your blue sky experience? How would you hope that info is transferred?
 - a. Really worried about her handover notes
 - i. ID partners at Cornell, at city agencies, RIOC, other institutions at Roosevelt Island

- ii. Sometimes programs start growing unexpectedly
 - iii. How we worked well/did not work well with folks
 - b. K-12 person has all of her notes since starting
- 8. Is there anything we didn't ask that you think we should have?
- 9. Contacts
 - a. Eden (PhD Student that runs the Community Service club) – she will email
 - b. Judy Birdie
 - c. Anyone else?
 - i. Niti Parikh (Maker Lab) – knows how to weave in

20260910 311NYC

- 11. Introductions: We're grad students at Cornell Tech looking for some expert guidance for a problem we've chosen to tackle around how cities might better learn what their residents need.
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- 14. ★ Could you lead us through (as you understand it) the step by step process for when a resident raises an issue/concern, where it's routed to, and what comes after? Feel free to provide as much or as little detail as you want to provide.
- 15. Where are the biggest pain points in learning what residents need or engaging with residents? What work do you do that can not be automated? What can be?
- 16. Did we miss anything?
- 17. Blue Sky?
- 18. Are there other folks in the city you'd recommend we speak to?
- 19. Thank you so much.
- 20. When someone files something
- 21. How does data get routed?
- 22.

20260909 Curren Mandon

Makerspace Not for Profit

- Relationship with government
 - Funding
 - Funding is mostly for upkeep, grant writing.
 - Nonprofits still get amount of money to keep running
 - Yearly/quarterly. Grant proposal to continue receive funding
 - Worked on a demographic survey with members and students, mix in feedback for their own sake. Background, ethnicity, diverse.

- 12-week Certification processes to get people back into the workforce “human-made”. Free certification. People still have to get paid to teach that.
 - Always a scramble to get everything through
 - Resources get them from partners
- About the SF Makerspace
 1. Certification process
 2. Membership (Students, corporate) & Volunteers
 3. Accelerator program (for businesses)
- Pain Points
 - Not only for people that have opportunities to pay can participate
 - Want to show that they're giving back to the community. Training people to find work. Showcase networking opportunities.
 - Next gen manufacturing training and accelerator (boosting for business)
 - Help members that aren't part of the programs
- Contacts - Erik and Grant Writers

20260910 Robbie Dornbush

Engaged citizen

- LinkNYC saw ads for 311 and knew about 311 but never thought would reach out to something random. If you see something you should say something and started to get in to the habit
- Earlier this summer and 6 am and saw firehydrant that was hit by car and was flooding into the streets. Called 311 to get it fixed. Pretty solid experience. Talked to rep in 2 minutes and was actual human and went back and forth with the issue and gave definitive next steps for what was going to happen but by the time got back it was fixed.
- Bigger issues, contact offices of local issues and try to figure out the best person to contact . background in government and politics and contacted member of congress. Communications of polling places. They weren't doing enough communications and call city council persons office.
- Difficult or painful
 - **Follow through.** Sometimes don't get call, or read receipt for email
 - What the office is even thinking of doing about it. Seeing progress is hard.
 - For 311, unless at home don't know when or if someone is coming . leads to just “hoping” it will be solved.
 - **Contacting** local office, have to call multiple offices to get there. Feels like a wild goose chase.
 - If you don't feel like you're being listened to, hurts your morale and desire and speak out because waste of time.
- Blue sky
 1. “Hot button issue” like expanding a bike lane or status of .

2. Keep track of those issues and hear what public officials. Have all that information aggregated. Policy decision making from local people actually.
- How do you prevent use or overuse of these systems. What percentage of 311 complaints actually. Are there power users that are driving majority of complaints.

20260908 Coach: Burke

1. Good morning Burke! Let's jump straight in. Today, we're to accomplish a few things [go through agenda]. We can coordinate a 30-min slot async.
2. 5min - Recap what we've done
 - a. 4Ps - Started google doc (~ 15 pages of good research)
 - b. Interviews - Interviewed head of community engagement
 - c. Rich Picture - Started FigJam
3. 5min - Approach (Due Sept 18) Aim for completion before Sept 15.
 - a. 4 Ps
 - b. 10+ logged interview
 - i. Speak to people who have used 311, people who deal with that data.
 - ii. Show up in person.
 - c. Job
4. 8min - Questions
 - a. Any advice on this approach?
 - b. Working with someone else working on government affairs – encouraged/discouraged?

20260904: Andrew Chang, Marielle Ali (Manhattan Director of Community Affairs + Liason)

Interview Guide:

1. (Rachel) Introductions: We're grad students at Cornell Tech looking for some expert guidance for a problem we've chosen to tackle around how cities might better learn what their residents need. Robbie's problem is similar – he's hoping to improve how communities shape the laws that govern them.
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4. ★ Could you lead us through (as you understand it) the step by step process for when a resident raises an issue/concern, where it's routed to, and what comes after? Feel free to provide as much or as little detail as you want to provide.
 - a. 1. In person, residents will share concerns. If its a policy/community related issue. Emails, phone calls, typed and handwritten letters sent to them. Very person dependent based.

- i. If not getting solved, then will show up to local electives, community boards, city office. Email do a google search, tag in social media.
 - ii. CBs are locally elected but not that many people know about them. Public meetings and
 - iii. If message blast, who is supposed to respond?
- b. 2. They are looking at Who are the stakeholders? Who are the relevant partners, agencies, etc. Who is affected and who has the power to resolve the issue? What are applicable laws that are relevant to this issue? Where is the enforcement coming from? What level? Don't deal with anything that involves court/legal means
- c. 3. They propagate information to the stakeholders and see what the history is. Have they dealt with this issue before? Recurring? If not pothole type issue, then long term issue (short term vs. long term issues).
- d. 4. Sometimes they'll have meetings with the city. If it's a major high level issue (what are examples of this), will go to the mayor's office. What's been done before, what has been done (is this information)
- e. 5. In terms of logging data, tell them to use 311 to log frequency of certain issues. For example, loud noises, sanitation issues in the neighborhood and city needs to look at data like that.
- f. Get the concerns from various means of comms
 - i. When we encounter people in person, they share concerns – ranges from specific tangible issues to larger policy based issues
 - ii. Still get typed and handwritten letters
 - iii. Get phone calls and emails
 - iv. Can be specific towards specific buildings
- g. After the learn about the issue, they analyze it
 - i. Who are the stakeholders involved (community, nonprofits, city agencies, etc)
 - ii. Who has the power to resolve the issue or introduce change
 - iii. What applicable laws exist // where is the enforcement coming from
 - iv. DO NOT deal with legal advice/court actions themselves
- h. From there, they communicate with relevant stakeholders and gather evidence
 - i. Submit what the constituent provides and supplement that with their own fact finding for accuracy
 - ii. Pass along whatever they have to the stakeholder, sometimes they involve mayor's office
 - iii. Look into the history of the issue in conversation with the stakeholder
 - iv. If it's a long-term issue, then there is continuous work needed to out city resources behind solving it
 - 1. What's been done before
 - 2. What can be done
 - v. Hopefully the issue gets addressed
- i. In terms of logging the data
 - i. Community members need to log through 311

- j. City agencies tend to focus on the issues that have the most complaints/data
 - i. Marielle emphasized the data point
 - ii. There are limited resources in terms of capacity
- k. Interesting in terms of how issues are raised
 - i. If someone is experiencing something, they know to call 311
 - ii. Some do not know/feel comfy to call 311
 - iii. If it hasn't been solved, then they might reach out to their local electeds
- l. Lots of different roles in the MBPO
 - i. Not legislatures
 - ii. Not their job to create bills
 - iii. If a constituent sends an email to everyone, then it creates a lock/confusion in terms of who should respond
- m. Community Boards are not as known as you;d like them to be
- 5. (Robbie) How would you characterize your relationship with the stakeholders you work with?
 - a. This group is powerful because they have mandated recurring meetings to provide feedback and update departments on things that are happening. City agencies will ask specific questions. Their opinion matters.
 - b. Borough presidents are always ADVISORY but it's a strong influence
 - i. Politics NYC story:
<https://politicsny.com/2026/09/04/inside-government-with-politicsny-a-qa-with-manhattan-borough-president-brad-hoylman-sigal/>
 - c. Marielle will share a write up that explains the relationship their office has
 - d. MBPO views the office as a convener and advocate
 - i. Example: If they are asked to contact the Dept. of Sanitation, they can do so through mandatory meetings with those agencies on a regular basis
 - ii. Regularly provide feedback in these forums
 - e. For electeds, they also act as convening role
 - i. MBPO does not have a formal role in City Council
 - ii. There is influence and advisory functions the office performs
 - iii. Very much a champion for the borough
 - f. City agencies know that the MBPO is contacted by constituents
 - i. City agencies look to MBPO for guidance
 - ii. Help elevate continuing issues to city agencies
- 6. (Mujtaba) *Fill in if needed*
- 7. (Rachel) Where are the biggest pain points in learning what residents need or engaging with residents? What work do you do that can not be automated? What can be?
 - a. Interagency coordination!!
 - i. When a Constituent reaches out, start copying every city agency on an email. Interagency coordination. Identify what the issue is. Sometimes its difficult to figure out who needs to do what, when and how. Who is leading these proposals.
 - b. Hard to identify who the owner will be and who will respond and who will be the lead

- c. There is more focus on this coordination recently
 - i. There has been a mindset change over time
 - ii. Access has encouraged more action on this front as well as folks are able to reach out and push more folks to contact more agencies and hold them accountable
- 8. What we missed: We come into this assuming they can advocate for themselves
 - a. That they know what 311 is
 - b. There are barriers that still exist from raising concerns on this kind of thing
 - c. Sometimes they get discouraged over time because government hasn't been responsive
 - d. Also the good news stories where gov is responsive don't get enough credit
- 9. ★ (Robbie) Are there other folks in the city you'd recommend we speak to?
 - a. Depends on things that are short term fixes vs long term fixes
 - i. Potholes = easy to fix
 - ii. For long term issues that are policy issues, its a harder issue to fix because we can't do much beyond sending social services/NYPD out
 - b. [Borough Board](#) – next one is 9/17 (recordings uploaded can also watch live)
 - i. Public meetings that the MBPO holds every month with the heads of community boards
 - ii. Each board is their own city agency
 - iii. Look into City Charter
 - iv. Includes Manhattan City Council Electeds (or their representatives)
 - v. Part of the convening power, the chairs of the convening boards and put through a resolution that calls for elected officials to engage community boards in those efforts
 - c. Capital/city funding: Can fix pothole
 - d. Homelessness in the park – lots of different types of issues
 - e. Data: OTI vs. Beta
 - f. Publicly available 311 data. DOB has own database for building violations and scaffolding, outstanding issues in fines.
 - i. BetaNYC <3 TY
 - ii. Public Advocate's Office
 - 1. Really their job to engage folks
 - g. Look at 3 branches of gov
 - i. Reach out to your local elected official
 - 1. Get a sense of how they do something
 - ii. Mayor's Office
 - 1. Office of Mass Engagement
 - 2. Civic Engagement Commission
 - iii. Legislative Branch
 - iv. City/County Court

Background/Other Notes:

- Contacts

- Andrew Chang (Community Liaison, CBs 1 & 2)
 - Handles constituent community issues
 - Both of which are in in Lower Manhattan
- Marielle Ali (Director of Community Affairs (CA), Manhattan)
 - Works with community board liaisons
 - Considered eyes and ears for the borough president
 - Report back what's happening at the hyper local level
- as an independent city agency of 50+ individuals, MBPO normally relies on traditional methods of community engagement (i.e. tabling at in-person community events on weekends, in-person announcements at Manhattan Community Board meetings, using social media platforms and a Mailchimp newsletter to engage readers, using LinkNYC kiosks to display digital flyers/announcements, and sharing information via email to community stakeholders and partners).

20260904 Studio Course

- Due next week are
 - Rich Picture
 - 4 P's
 - 10+ logged interviews

20260903 Advisor: David Opatrny

Slack Message

Hi Team,

To keep ourselves accountable and you updated, we wanted to use this space to share brief ad-hoc progress updates. On Tuesday, we had our first sync with our coach, Burke Reimann and today we had our first meeting with our industry advisor, David Opatrny.

20260901 - Coach Sync

After introductions, we discussed

- Scope (Lodging residents or NYC residents? Decide based on 4P research)
- Advice on approach strategy (validate before building, rapid mockups in tandem with direct user feedback)
- Listen well and have agency!

20260903 - Advisor Sync

After introductions, we discussed

- Advice on potential approaches (framing around mayoral concerns, gov-contract companies, simplifying early builds)
- Technical questions (data sourcing, data consolidation, predicted tech stack/necessary skills, etc.)

- Logistics (weekly cadence)

See more detailed notes [HERE](#).

Consolidated Notes

Location: Zoom

Date and Time: Sept 3rd 2026, 9:40-10:10 AM

Attendees: David Opatrny (Industry Advisor), Rachel Liu (ORIE), Muhammad Mujtaba Asghar (MBA)

Agenda:

1. Introductions - background, why we're interested in this project
2. David's initial thoughts / MVP thinking
3. Our questions for David

Introductions:

- David: currently at Cyera, working as the principle solution architect. Previously at GitHub (telemetry), prior background in data infrastructure, has been PM at a manufacturing company (process automation, data systems). Cornell Tech '22 alum.

David's initial thoughts / MVP

- "Watch, don't ask": observe how the city tries to get things done, capture those signals (bonus for AI-assisted interpretation)
- Find a north star tied to real city concerns (housing, transit, ridership, records) and look for correlations/friction points
- Frame around what the mayor cares about, not an abstract data project
- Avoid the "build trap": keep early builds simple (public APIs, basic Python ETL); focus energy on derisking assumptions first
- Get familiar with: event-driven agent harnesses, progressive crystallization, broker systems, API auth for messy data
- Novel raw data vs. novel processed data: both can be valuable/monetizable (e.g. his AEO-data friend)

Our questions & David's answers

- What can you advise us on? *Technical feasibility, plus broader strategy*
- Data sources? *Public records, video feeds, ridership/transit data, housing data; explore correlations*
- When to think about scaling? *After initial validation/derisking, once problem is proven*

- Hard skills needed? *Data science, data engineering, database management, plus basic ETL/API/LLM familiarity*
- Cadence? *Weekly*

Strategy:

- Use network/LinkedIn for city gov connections
- Look at public-interest organisations with data problems for pain points

Possible stack:

- AWS, RabbitMQ/MQTT for signal retrieval

Next steps:

- David to help with city data sourcing
- Weekly cadence going forward
- Follow up via work email

Raw Notes

-

Agenda

1. Introduction - background, why we are interested in this project?
 - a. working in Github. Telemetry
 - b. Prior to that, data infrastructure
 - c. Product manager at manufacturing company. Process automation, data systems.
 - d. Graduated from cornell tech class of 2022 and all managers are from cornell tech
 - e. Where he could be most useful. Thinking about approaching problems from a data approach. Problems getting interviews. Product. Immersed in AI space.
 - f. Interested in this one because a lot of the PI ones were cool. In particular Pick 25 and put it in order. Government doesn't deeply understand product management. Data question and discovery question.
 - g. Overwhelming in scale. Will be interesting to see which aspects we want to attack.
 - h. Boundaries around engagement
2. His initial thoughts on this problem, what would you do? What is MVP in your mind (of course we will do broad exploration but still curious)
 - a. Watch! Don't ask. What are ways we can watch a city attempt to get things done. And what are ways we can consume those signals. Bonus points between AI

- b. What is the deterministic and probabilistic aspect for the things they are trying to optimize.
 - c. North star - align to the various concerns to. Housing, Transportation. Ask about particular friction points between publicly available data. Public records the city has. Investment. Ridership totals. Correlation. Income. Video feeds. Questions. Skys the limit.
 - d. At its core.- how could you package this in novel in asking about a process that's important
 - e. What does the mayor care about and what are they trying to shift. Matrix vs existing city concerns.
 - f. Strategies
 - i. Scrape LinkedIn and find out if know anyone to city government.
 - g. Micro
 - i. Public interest corporations with data problems and find them in your network. What are pain points when you pitch things to the city.
 - h. Build trap is ever present. Public APIs, Some time of ETL (keep it easy and just load something in Python), building and loading databases. Basic familiarity with how to interact with LLMs and what a "harness", "event driven agent harness", "progressive chyrystalization". One thing you have to do over time and look for what can be crystallized into deterministic code. "Broker systems". . Modularized Optimization problem when has suffieicnt data.
 - i. API management question with. Assuming assumptions hold true. "Highly reductionist". I have lots of unstructured chaotic data. How to do Auth, how to securely connect with these things.
 - j. What about new databases? What are new columns that we add (another new layer) Friend that is doing data around AEO optimizations (would love to buy his data). Frequently very valuable. Novel way of hooking things out there. Novel raw data vs novel processed data and has multiple sales ch
 - k. initial validation and mitigation problem. Energy you have is best spent derisking some of these things
3. Questions
- a. What can you/do you want to advise us on? Technical feasibility? What else?
 - b. What data sources do you recommend we tap into?
 - c. When do we start thinking about scaling?
 - d. What hard skills do we need to employ? Data science, data engineering, database management?
 - e. What cadence do you want to meet us?
 - i. Guidance is once a week.
 - ii. Use work email.

Mujtaba:

Notes of meeting with David:

Introduction from both of us David.

Watch don't ask, what other various ways should a city watch, identify data structures, have a probabilistic element of this. Have an AI thinking. Northstar, align with what the city government wants to do. Public records that the city, housing, video feeds, congestion in subway, infrastructure. How can you package this which is novel. What does the mayor care about? What does he need? Public interest corporations might have data problems. We need to pitch our project for the city.

David to help us with the data sourcing from the city government.

Be handy with Public APIs, ETL, Simple Python script in python for ETL, Initial Validated Problem, How to build and load database, what a harness looks like, LLMs, progressive crystallisation, event driven agent harness, optimisation problem, API management question.

David has a friend who has been building a database around AEO.

Novel data collection sources vs Processed Data

SRS, AWS, Rabbit MQTT allowing a signal retrieval system.

Cadence with David to be initiated for his advice.

20260901 Coach: Burke Reimann

Consolidated Notes:

- Listen to the market before building — validate before committing to an idea
- Don't build based on personal vision alone; build only what people say they want and would find valuable
- Best founders act as listeners with strong agency, not as unchecked visionaries
- Build in tandem with user conversations: high-level talks to surface pain points, then rapid mockups (e.g., "by Friday, mock up a solution to what you just described")
- Start building early — don't wait for full clarity

Raw Notes

Check-Ins: Our weekly check-in is scheduled for Tuesdays at 9:40am ET. Please use [this link](#) to access that meeting. If you'd like to meet more outside of our check-in, just book time at [this link here](#) (it's my calendly)

5. Thank you for meeting with us Burke! How do you feel about some quick intros then jumping straight into the project?
6. 30s/pp - Quick Intros
7. 5min - Approach
 - a. We've discussed between ourselves, but curious to know how you would approach this problem
 - b. Data sourcing or data consolidation - that was our initial thinking
 - c. Who are the players here? The 4 Ps. Tenants? Low Income housing?
8. 8min - Questions
 - a. How to best pace the project
 - b. Do's and don't's.
 - c. Does it have to be prototype or commercialized
 - d. What resources should we tap into

Who would be part of this?

Tenants

Multi Family

What tool would you give to someone

Do - Listen to the market

Residents - lodging? What does it

Do actually build something that's fully functioning

Advise

- Don't get
- Don't build crazy idea unless people say they want it and that it's worth building
- Best founders are the best listeners and best agency - Try not to be a visionary right off the bat
- Building in tandem. High level conversation with pain points. "On Friday can we mock up something to a solution you just describe"
- Start whenever you want, start early, build early.

Next Steps

- ☐ Both - Team Agreement
- ☒ Rachel - ~~Airtable Demo (Kanban board)~~ - Planning - Milestone - Some Tools
- ☒ Rachel - ~~Set Up GitHub Repo~~
- ☐ Both - Research

- Coding Tools (Collaboration)
- Use Framework of the 4 Ps
- Come up with questions
- Data sources available to us

Questions

- Do and Don'ts for deploying
 - What data source should we use and why?
 - What are some products that are currently in the market and what can we learn from them
-